

CORE FORMULA

Point -> Reason -> Evidence / Example -> Point (restate)

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before answering any important question, identify: what is my point? One reason. One example. Then restate the point.

BEST FOR

- Interview and viva-style questions
- Presentations and pitches
- Any situation where you need to structure a verbal argument
- Avoiding rambling when put on the spot

PHRASE BANK

PREP Phrases · Signalling the structure

- "My view is [Point]. The reason is [Reason]. For example, [Example]. So I would say [Point]."
- "I would answer that in two parts — the principle and the example."
- "Let me give you the direct answer, then the evidence."
- "Short version: [Point]. The reason I say that is [Reason]."
- "The way I think about it is: [Point] — and here is why."
- "I can answer that in one sentence and then give you a concrete example."
- "The point I want to make is [Point], because [Reason]."

Example Bridges · Moving to evidence

- "A concrete example of that is..."
- "The clearest instance I have seen was..."
- "In practice, this looks like..."
- "I can give you a recent example:"
- "That showed up clearly when..."

Mini-PREP · The structure at conversational size

- "Yes — because it saves us a week. We saw that on the last sprint. So yes."
- "I would skip it. Low turnout last time. Skip it."
- "Worth doing: cheap, fast, and it worked in March."
- "No — the numbers do not support it. They did not in Q2 either."
- "My take: go early. Early worked for the pilot. Go early."

PREP Under Pressure · Interviews, vivas and put-on-the-spot moments

- "Let me answer that directly, then give you my evidence."
- "My position has three parts: the claim, the reason, and what I saw that convinced me."
- "I will give you my conclusion first and then defend it."
- "That is a fair challenge — my answer is X, and here is the strongest case for it."
- "Give me ten seconds to structure this properly, because it deserves a clear answer."

Point Restaters · Closing the loop

- "So, coming back to where I started: X."
- "Which is exactly why I say X."
- "All of that points the same way: X."

- "So my answer stands: X."
- "That is the evidence — and it is why I hold the view."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Rambling answer with no clear point
Better: There are several factors involved here...
Best: My view is X. The reason is Y. The clearest example is Z. So: X.
2. Weak: Example without a point: 'Well, one time I did this thing...'
Better: Here is a relevant experience...
Best: State the point first. Then the example to back it.
3. Weak: Strong point, no evidence: 'I believe X.'
Better: I believe X, and I have seen evidence of it.
Best: Point, specific reason, concrete example, restate point.

DECISION TREE

If You are asked an open-ended question with no structure

Use PREP. State your point first.

"My view is... The reason I say that is..."

If You are rambling and losing your thread

Stop. Restate the point. Then give one reason.

"Let me come back to the main point — it is simply: ..."

If They are pressing for more than a point

Move to reason, then example.

"The reason I hold that view is X. A concrete example is Y."

If Your example is weak or vague

Use a specific, real situation — not a theoretical one.

"A real instance of that was..."

If You are using PREP too rigidly and it sounds mechanical

Keep the logic but vary the phrasing.

"I think X, and here is the best evidence I have for it."

SCENARIOS

Interview: 'Tell me about a challenge you have faced'

Point: the challenge. Reason: why it was hard. Example: what happened. Point: what you learned. — "The challenge was X. The reason it was difficult was Y. In practice, it looked like Z. What I took from it is..."

Meeting: 'What do you think we should do?'

State your recommendation. Give the main reason. Give one example. Restate. — "I think we should do X. The main reason is Y. We have seen that in Z. So my recommendation stands."

Pitch: making a case for your idea

Use PREP as the spine of each major point. — "The core argument is X. The evidence behind it is Y. A concrete example is Z. So: X."

Viva/oral exam: defending your work

Answer the examiner's question with PREP before expanding. — "My position is X. The theoretical basis is Y. My data showed Z. Which brings me back to X."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In deeply emotional conversations where structure feels cold and clinical.
- In creative or brainstorming sessions where open-ended flow is more valuable than structured argument.
- When the relationship and context call for natural conversation rather than presentation mode.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Identify the structure

In your next conversation, notice whether your answers have a clear point, reason, and example. Do not change anything yet.

Day 2 — Point first

In three answers today, state your position in the first sentence before explaining.

Day 3 — One reason

After making your point, give one specific reason. Not three reasons — one.

Day 4 — Concrete example

Practice attaching a concrete real-world example to one position you hold.

Day 5 — Restate the point

After each PREP answer, add the final sentence that restates your point.

Day 6 — Full PREP in practice

Use the full structure to answer one important question today.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your answers feel clearer? Did people respond more directly? Did any structure feel forced?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state my position (Point) in the first sentence?
- Did I give one clear reason — not a list of reasons?
- Did I use a concrete, specific example — not a hypothetical?
- Did I restate the point at the end?
- Did the structure feel natural — not mechanical?
- Did I avoid rambling past the example?
- Did the person I was speaking to seem to follow my argument clearly?